

The Limits of Local Elections Under Subnational Authoritarianism: Evidence From Nigeria *

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Abstract

When do local government (LG) elections fail to improve public service delivery? Using Nigeria as a case study, we develop a theory of electoral institutions that explains how unconstrained subnational executives can exploit decentralized electoral institutions to disrupt democratic accountability at the local level, thereby neutralizing the incentive to provide adequate public services. By absorbing electoral institutions into clientelistic political machines, Nigerian governors can influence both the selection of candidates and election outcomes themselves. Nigerian governors are known to illegally cancel local elections and instead directly appoint "caretaker" committees. Where local elections were held, the political party of state governors has consistently won an overwhelming majority of all LG chairmanship elections. Using data on healthcare and education outcomes from the Nigerian General Household Survey (2010-2018) and a difference-in-differences design, we find that elected local leaders perform no better than appointed ones, across various model specifications. Consequently, we conclude that the introduction of LG elections are of little significance to Nigeria's public services due to the capture of both the LG electoral process and LG funds by state governors. This research contributes to a growing literature on subnational authoritarianism, showing how decentralized electoral institutions, often promoted as vehicles to further democratization, can instead be weaponized by subnational authoritarian leaders to entrench their control.

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1. INTRODUCTION

In July 2024, the Nigerian Supreme Court ruled that all states in the country must hold elections for local government (LG) councils to be eligible to receive their monthly funding allocations from the Federation Account Allocation Committee (FAAC). This ruling addressed a chronic and systemic problem in Nigeria’s decentralized democracy. Election irregularities are widespread. Governors often cancel local elections outright and directly appoint loyalists. When elections do occur, the results are often disputed, sometimes leading to the nullification of results. State Independent Electoral Commissions, tasked with carrying out local elections with impartiality, have been subject to political pressure from state governors, who frequently manipulate local elections. In such a context, do local elections matter for public service delivery?

A considerable volume of literature has sought to explain the spatial variation in the quality of public goods and services across different types of government, finding evidence that accountability mechanisms such as elections promote better quality public goods (Grossman and Slough, 2022). Further research has suggested that local elections in decentralized states can encourage governments to align public goods with local preferences and/or increase spending (Enikolopov and Zhuravskaya, 2007; Harding and Stasavage, 2014; Bunte and Kim, 2017; Martinez-Bravo et al., 2022; Arora and Rao, 2023). However, some evidence suggests that local elections can sometimes fail to improve public goods (Lewis, 2017; Marumahoko et al., 2020; Lewis and Dong, 2025).

We argue that variation in effectiveness of local elections to improve public goods can be attributed to two factors: the degree of (de)centralization of electoral institutions, and the degree of constraints on subnational executives. Decentralized electoral institutions can function properly in democratic governments where subnational executives face constraints to arbitrary rule. However, in contexts where subnational authoritarianism is rampant, decentralized electoral institutions are especially vulnerable to capture by unconstrained subnational executives. When this occurs, subnational elections generate results that resemble direct appointments, because these corrupted elections draw from the same pool of officials to fill local positions that appointments would otherwise draw from. In extreme cases that occur not infrequently in Nigeria, unconstrained governors may simply cancel elections altogether and appoint local officials directly, conserving time and resources while having little effect on the outcome. In short, we argue that in contexts where electoral institutions are decentralized and subnational executives face little constraints, there is little difference between elected or appointed LG officials. This paper is in line with research on subnational authoritarianism, which examines the phenomenon of pockets of authoritarian rule existing within federalist

government structures that remain democratic at the national level (Benton, 2012; Gibson, 2013; Grumbach, 2023). Decentralized government systems can provide opportunities for subnational leaders to behave in an authoritarian manner.

Nigeria provides a unique case for studying the relationship between LG elections and the provision of public goods and services. Since Nigeria’s transition from military rule to civilian democracy in 1999 and subsequent decentralization, conditions were laid in place that should have led to an improvement of public goods. However, this democratic transition proceeded unevenly, as there is considerable variation between Nigerian states in the adherence to democratic governance. Both qualitative and quantitative evidence in Nigeria suggest possible impediments to the positive effect of local democracy on public goods (Samuel et al., 2021; Page and Wando, 2022; Olaleye, 2023), which are consistent with findings in the neighboring region (Resnick, 2014; Marumahoko et al., 2020). Notably, Fetzer and Kyburz (2024) examines Nigerian LGs in the context of distributive conflicts over resource rents, finding that political violence is more likely to erupt in the Local Government Areas (LGAs) governed by unelected local councils.

We argue that this prevalence of subnational authoritarianism within Nigerian states prevents elections from serving as a meaningful accountability mechanism for LGs, and thus inhibits the ability of local elections to improve the provision of public goods. We expect that the quality of public goods within the LGAs of Nigeria will not respond to the elections that take place. In other words, we expect to LGs ruled by elected councils to not meaningfully differ in public goods provision from LGs ruled by unelected councils.

We rely on data on elected LG status, as well as data on healthcare service delivery from the Nigerian General Household Survey (GHS) between 2010 and 2018. We use a difference-in-differences estimator designed to allow for heterogeneous treatment effects (de Chaisemartin and d’Haultfoeuille, 2024). We find that access to public services in Nigerian LGAs whose officials are elected does not differ significantly from LGAs whose officials were directly appointed. This result is robust to multiple model specifications. LGAs governed by elected or appointed officials appear to perform similarly in the delivery of public services. These results suggest that Nigeria’s local democracy system has failed to lead to an improvement in the quality of public goods.

This paper’s contributions are threefold. First, we deepen existing literature on subnational authoritarianism (Gibson, 2005, 2013) by showing that electoral institutions themselves can be vulnerable to capture by subnational authoritarian leaders. Second, we connect literature on electoral management bodies (Kerr, 2024; James, 2017) to the broader discussion of democratic accountability, showing that elite capture of these institutions neutralizes the pressures of accountability exerted by elections. Finally, we contribute to

the literature on decentralization and public services (Grossman and Slough, 2022; Harding and Stasavage, 2014) by identifying a specific institutional arrangement that counteracts the positive effect of democracy on public service delivery.

This paper proceeds as follows. In Section 2, we review existing literature on decentralization, distributive politics, and subnational authoritarianism, and lay out our theory. Then, in Section 3, we provide an overview of Nigeria’s local political institutions and state our testable hypothesis. Section 4 lays out our research design, including data sources and statistical procedures, while Section 5 details our results. Finally, we conclude by discussing the implications of our results for the broader literature.

2. ELECTORAL INSTITUTIONS AND SUBNATIONAL AUTHORITARIANISM

2.1. ELECTIONS AND SERVICE DELIVERY

Elections at any level can provide a powerful incentive for leaders to respond to their constituents (Fearon, 1999), encouraging leaders to provide public goods to their constituents rather than private goods targeted at elite supporters (de Mesquita et al., 2002). Because winning elections requires attracting a broader base of support than non-democratic methods of leader selection, widely available public goods are a more cost-efficient method of attracting popular support than private goods. In fact, evidence suggests that voters reward politicians for public goods (Harding, 2015). In India, a sudden postponement of local elections created a natural experiment, which provided evidence showing that elected LGs were better able to align public goods spending with citizen preferences (Arora and Rao, 2023). In the United States, evidence suggests a relationship between greater voter information on local politician performance and the quality of public education (Berry and Howell, 2007; M. and Strömberg, 2010).

Despite theoretical and empirical support for the relationship between elections and public goods provision, there still appear to be some conflicting accounts (Nelson, 2007). For example, evidence from Indonesia suggests that the establishment of LGs not only failed to improve the provision of public goods, but also led to misappropriation of municipal funds by local leaders (Lewis, 2017; Lewis and Dong, 2025). Keefer (2007) demonstrates that, in low-income democracies, elected leaders can reallocate resources to small groups of voters, at the expense of other voters. In fact, clientelism and vote buying often disrupt the accountability function of elections (Hicken and Nathan, 2020; Cruz et al., 2021). Interestingly, Harding and Stasavage (2014) show that, while African democracies tend to have better school attendance rates than non-democracies, this appears to be due to expanding access to school, rather than increasing inputs. Furthermore, government

decentralization can sometimes lead to worse outcomes (Robinson, 2007; Marumahoko et al., 2020), by providing local leaders more opportunities for corruption (Gupta et al., 2003), or by making it more difficult for voters to identify who is responsible for (un)successful public goods projects (Zarychta, 2020).¹

2.2. SUBNATIONAL AUTHORITARIANISM, CAPTURE, AND ACCOUNTABILITY

Although there is evidence linking elections to improved public goods provision in both national and subnational contexts, the evidence to the contrary warrants further investigation. Following the literature on subnational authoritarianism (Gibson, 2005; Benton, 2012; Gibson, 2013), we argue that allowing for a conceptual separation between national-level democracy and subnational-level authoritarianism, both co-existing within the same nation, can explain the peculiar failure of local-level democratic accountability mechanisms. The existence of elections is by no means incompatible with authoritarianism at any level. Indeed, existing literature on elections under authoritarianism describe the mechanisms by which elections can help stabilize authoritarian regimes, for example, through information gathering (Enikolopov and Zhuravskaya, 2007), recruiting competent officials (Gehlbach and Keefer, 2012). However, the manipulation or outright refusal to hold elections is a defining characteristic of authoritarianism. Free and fair elections are vulnerabilities to authoritarian regimes, as they can provide opportunities for regime opponents to enter office (Resnick, 2023), and acquire information on government popularity (Miller, 2015). Directly appointed officials are more likely to carry out the governors' interests (Martinez-Bravo et al., 2022), and are useful tools for turning out votes for incumbent party leaders (Minaeva et al., 2023). This, however, comes at the cost of undermining the provision of public goods (Beazer and Reuter, 2022).

To explain why subnational elections can fail to improve public goods, we conceptualize subnational governments within federalist political systems as varying along two dimensions: the degree of constraint on subnational executives, and the degree of centralization of electoral institutions.² By electoral institutions, we mean the specific bodies that are responsible for carrying out the administrative work that make elections possible, the electoral management bodies (EMBs). *Centralized* systems, allow for elections to be conducted by a single national EMB, whereas *decentralized* systems allow multiple EMBs serving different jurisdictions. Each institutional arrangement has consequences for those whom elected LG officials are accountable to.

¹For an extended overview of the literature on the relationship between accountability mechanisms and the provision of public goods and services, see (Grossman and Slough, 2022).

²In an ongoing study, we, along with other co-authors compile a global dataset of election management bodies classified as either centralized or decentralized in their administration of elections in their countries. We analyze whether the differences in centralization has any impact for election integrity and autonomy of the electoral management body. We also study how insulated these institutions are from capture by national and subnational executives and how it may differ based on their level of centralization.

Democratic governance structures tend to feature constraints on executives, but there is variation, especially at the subnational level. As we’ll argue below, the combination of decentralized EMBs and unconstrained subnational executives can render subnational polities vulnerable to authoritarianism and thus neutralize the positive effect on public goods provision that democratic accountability mechanisms would otherwise have. And, importantly, this can all happen even as the government at the national level remains democratic.

Conventional theories of democracy often point to constraints on executives as a defining characteristic of democracy itself (Magaloni and Kricheli, 2010). We apply this same logic to the subnational context. We argue that, like chief executives at the national level, subnational executive leaders within federalist structures also vary in the degree of the institutional constraints to their rule, and, crucially, this need not correspond to constraints at the national level to national executives (Gibson, 2005). In other words, in countries that are nominally democratic at the national level, provincial or state governors may still inhabit a state/province-level institutional framework that exerts relatively weaker constraints on their rule. Like their national-level counterparts, subnational executives can face the presence (or absence) of opposition emanating from a (subnational) legislature, judiciary, and/or civil society. An unconstrained subnational executive, therefore, is defined the weakness or absence of veto-points that would otherwise impede arbitrary rule.

We emphasize electoral management bodies (EMBs) as critical institutions within electoral systems (Kerr, 2024; James, 2017, 2013). EMBs are the bureaucratic institutions that perform the task of tabulating voters’ ballots and determining the outcome. As Kerr elaborates, EMBs vary by the degree of autonomy allotted to them.³ Because these institutions directly carry out elections, their impartiality is critical for the maintenance of free and fair elections. However, when these institutions face pressure from the political leaders whose elections they are tasked with overseeing, the elections are then vulnerable to fraud. We define decentralized electoral institutions as a design for an electoral system whereby elections at the subnational level are administered by subnational EMBs, which operate independently of oversight from national-level governing bodies. Subnational EMBs in a decentralized electoral system are thus solely responsible for carrying out subnational elections within their own respective state/provinces, and are not directly accountable to the national government. Conversely, a centralized electoral system is one where elections at all levels are administered by a national-level EMB. Table 1 shows four possible cases and the type of accountability that results with differences in centralization and constraint of subnational executives.

³Kerr (2024) conceptualizes EMBs along two dimensions: autonomy and capacity. In this present study, we choose to emphasize on the autonomy dimension.

Table 1: Electoral Institutions, Executive Constraints, and Accountability

	Centralized EMBs	Decentralized EMBs
Constrained Executive	Accountable to public <i>Example: South Africa</i>	Accountable to public <i>Example: Australia</i>
Unconstrained Executive	Accountable to national <i>Example: Türkiye</i>	Unaccountable <i>Example: Nigeria</i>

Notes: The typology classifies subnational institutional configurations by whether subnational executives face effective constraints from legislatures and judiciaries, and whether there are multiple EMBs with distinct geographical jurisdiction or a single national EMB. Our theory predicts that electoral institutional capture, and consequently the failure of elections to improve public goods, occurs specifically in the bottom-right quadrant.

Recent literature on subnational authoritarianism tends to focus on federalism more broadly. For example, work by Grumbach and Michener (2022) shows how federalism in the United States can provide opportunities for economic and political elites to entrench their own control by upholding barriers that exclude marginalized and less powerful groups. Moreover, Grumbach (2023) addresses elections specifically, by investigating the performance of democratic institutions amid apparent attempts to influence outcomes via gerrymandering, imposing barriers to registration, and other mechanisms. However, these approaches focus on subnational polities that are decentralized via federalism but without directly addressing the electoral institutions themselves. Notably, decentralized electoral institutions are not a defining characteristic of federalist political systems. For example, South Africa has a decentralized three-tier government (national, provincial, and municipal), as well as a centralized EMB that is tasked with administering elections at all three levels. Research on democratic performance that places federalism at the conceptual center may risk attributing poor outcomes to federalism that could be more precisely attributed to the elite capture of decentralized EMBs.

Nigeria, the subject of the present study, exemplifies a combination of decentralized electoral institutions and unconstrained subnational executives, as we will describe in the following section. In our typology, Nigeria falls into the fourth quadrant of Table 1. The Nigerian political system at the subnational level shares the same power asymmetries between executive and legislative branches that are observed at the national level. Nigerian governors routinely engage in behavior that local observers describe as corrupt, and yet face little obstacles. Thus, the elected local officers that are produced by this captured system are not accountable to the public, but instead to the governor whose captured electoral institutions allowed them into their positions.

Contrary to conventional wisdom, the decentralization of subnational electoral institutions can sometimes

expose a vulnerability to manipulation. In countries with centralized electoral institutions, the leadership of those EMBs are typically selected at the national level by the national government. State or provincial leaders are entirely excluded from the leadership selection process for centralized electoral institutions, and therefore have no direct influence on this process. For this reason, would-be subnational authoritarian leaders are denied a mechanism for the manipulation of subnational elections: the election commissions are beyond their control. This doesn't necessarily preclude attempts at election manipulation by other means, of course, only that the mechanism of manipulation via capture of electoral institutions is unavailable.

However, where electoral institutions are decentralized, and subnational elections are administered by subnational EMBs whose leadership is chosen by subnational-level governments, these electoral institutions are vulnerable to direct pressure or capture by subnational executives. In pockets of subnational authoritarianism, where provincial governors face few formal or informal constraints to arbitrary rule, a subnational EMB that is severed from national-level oversight can be absorbed into a subnational clientelistic political machine. When this occurs, the integrity of elections can be threatened. Authoritarian governors can influence the selection process for leadership and/or staffing for these institutions, installing incumbent partisans, and thus ensuring that subnational election outcomes are favorable to the governor's interests. In extreme cases, these captured electoral institutions may simply comply with governors' orders to refuse to hold elections altogether. The institutions responsible for carrying out subnational elections can become complicit in their erosion. As we will describe in the next section, this is precisely the case in contemporary Nigeria post-democratization.

3. LOCAL GOVERNMENTS IN NIGERIA

Here, we provide a qualitative overview of Nigeria's political context and history, detailing how Nigeria's unconstrained governors have influenced decentralized electoral institutions. Nigeria has a total of 774 LGAs, spread out across the 36 states and Federal Capital Territory.⁴ These LGAs are the lowest tier of government in Nigeria, under the state and national governments. These LGs are divided into electoral wards of between 10 and 13, each of which produces a councilor who governs the LG together with the chairperson of the LG.

⁴There are only 6 LGAs in the FCT. The FCT is governed by a minister who is a member of the national executive cabinet and not directly elected in elections like the governors of states.

3.1. LOCAL GOVERNMENTS AND SERVICE DELIVERY

Nigeria was one of the first nations in the region to decentralize the provision of public goods, transferring the responsibility to LGAs (Gupta et al., 2003). The broad objective of establishing LG was to focus on service delivery at the grassroots level (Bunte and Kim, 2017). However, this decentralization of the provision of public goods has not lived up to expectations. Evidence suggests that significant amounts of funding intended for public goods are unaccounted for (Khemani, 2006; Adeyemi, 2013). Despite formal decentralization, poor public goods outcomes are attributed to state government authorities withholding LG funding intended for public goods (Samuel et al., 2021).

Since 1999, governors have used their own interpretation of Section 162 of the Constitution to withhold and manipulate federally allocated funds to LGs. In July 2024, the Supreme Court addressed the prevalence of governors illegally dissolving LGs, ruling that appointed "caretaker" committees are illegal and that councils run by them should not receive federal allocation. The court also ruled that the allocations should go directly to the accounts of the 774 local councils instead. As of 2025, LGs have not opened accounts and FAAC allocations still go to state governments (PunchNewspapers, 2025).⁵

Despite the explicit mandate and fiscal resources allocated to Local Government Councils (LGCs)⁶, effective service delivery is often compromised by political and administrative failures. A major constraint in effective service delivery is the weakness of local accountability, which often leads to the leakage or diversion of public resources. A striking feature revealed by surveys is the extensive non-payment of health personnel salaries by LGCs. In Kogi State, 42 percent of health staff reported not receiving any salary for six months or more in the year prior to the 2002 survey (Gupta et al., 2003). This problem cannot be explained by a lack of resources, as evidence shows that budget allocations were often sufficient to cover estimated staff costs. Non-payment of salaries forces facility staff to behave as private providers, resulting in more services provided through home visits and essential drugs being privately provided, sometimes funded by staff's own resources or by expropriating facility stocks. Furthermore, non-payment of salaries has resulted in the closure of health facilities in Kogi.

⁵In Akwa Ibom State, Governor Udom Emmanuel allocated 31 new SUV Prado jeeps to each LG chairman to enhance their operational capabilities and reward grassroots engagement efforts. The vendor details were not disclosed. Meanwhile, in Cross River State, Governor Ben Ayade distributed 54 new SUVs, providing Ford Edge models to chairmen, Ford Escape to vice chairmen, and Ford Eco Sport to council leaders. Acquisitions were funded through joint account allocations committee (JAAC) accounts using LG funds, considered an 'entitlement' to meet mobility demands.

⁶LGCs receive about 20 percent of total federal resources in the divisible pool, largely from oil revenues

3.2. LOCAL GOVERNMENT ELECTIONS IN NIGERIA

Nigeria has a decentralized electoral system, where national-level and gubernatorial elections are administered by a national-level Independent National Election Commission (INEC), and local elections are administered by State Independent Election Commissions (SIECs). While the leadership of the INEC is selected by the national government, it is the state governments who select the leadership of SIECs. Each state has its own SIEC that operates independently of the INEC. At the local level, the legislation that governs LGs varies from state to state. There is no uniformity in the tenure or timing of LG elections, and elections do not occur at regular intervals (Etebom, 2024)⁷.

Throughout Nigeria, it is common for governors to illegally refuse to hold local elections for these positions altogether. LG institutions have long been used by governors to ‘settle’ members of his party and his cronies. Apart from the Chairmanship positions, there are positions such as Vice Chairman and Councilor, most of which usually employ a retinue of aides such as Special Assistants, Technical Assistants, and Personal Assistants. These positions that should normally be elected are instead doled out as rewards to loyal partisans. These unelected and illegally appointed LGCs are called “caretaker” committees. This is a frequent point of contention in local politics, with major civil society organizations, such as the Nigerian Union of LG Employees, issuing statements claiming that unelected LG chairmen lack the mandate of the people (Itodo, 2024).

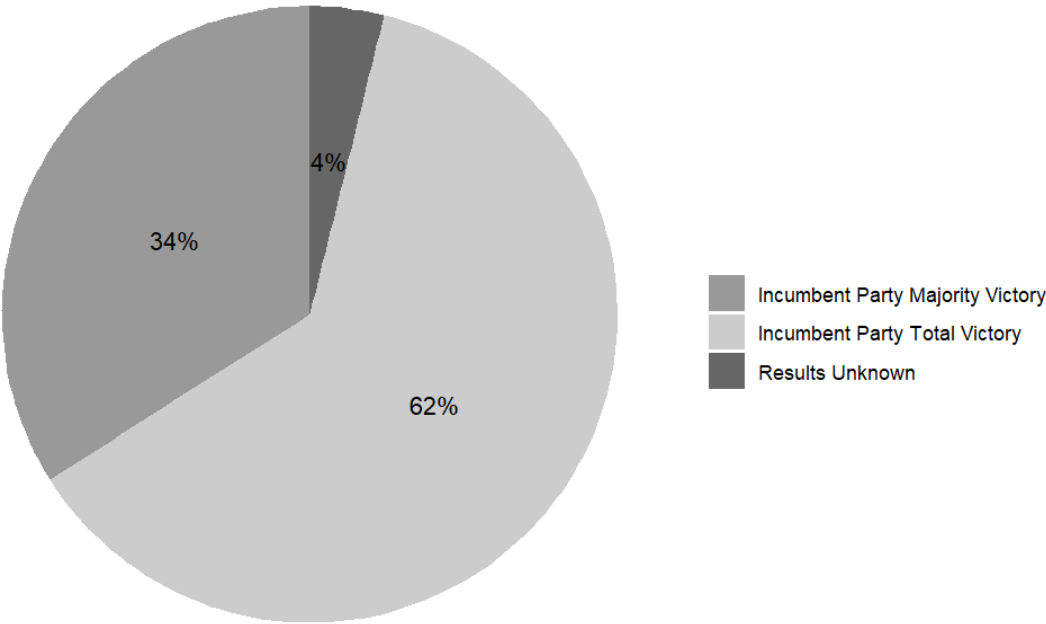
When LG elections are held, the incumbent governors’ party typically wins overwhelmingly, frequently claiming all contested seats. According to our own investigation of 104 LGA elections held throughout Nigeria from 2010 to 2023, the incumbent governor’s party won virtually all elections. Figure 1 plots our findings (see also Figure A1 in the appendix for statistics on LG elections across states in Nigeria for this period). We were unable to identify a single documented instance of an opposition party winning a majority of open chairmanships or councilors in a LG election. Opposition party wins in LG elections are limited to the margins, rarely claiming more than 5% of seats. In most LG elections, the incumbent governor’s party claims total victory of all chairmanships and councilors, that is, 100% of seats were claimed by the incumbent party. In the remaining races where results were publicly announced, the governor’s party claims overwhelming majority. For example, APC won 176 out of 177 councilors in the 2021 Ekiti elections and 346 out of 349 in councilors in the 2016 Ogun elections. In contrast, PDP won 258 of the 260 councilors

⁷Page and Wando (2022) show that since 2008, states have had less frequent LG elections. Figure A1 in the appendix shows the number of LG elections held by states between 2010 and 2023. During this 13 year period, some states like Anambra held only 1 election.

in the 2017 Enugu elections and 202 of the 203 councilors in the 2016 Ondo elections. Another analysis conducted by Premium Times, a Nigerian news outlet, examined 18 elections conducted since the Supreme Court ruling of 2024 addressing election issues, showing that ruling parties won all chairmanship seats, with two exceptions being in the Akwa Ibom and Rivers states (Majeed, 2024).

FIGURE 1 ABOUT HERE

Figure 1: Local Government Election Outcomes by Governor Party Incumbency



Note: Data are LG election results from 2010 to 2023, arranged by election outcome. In nearly all cases, the incumbent governor’s party won overwhelming majorities of LG chairmanships and councilors, with the modal outcome being total victory of all open seats. We could find no documented instances in which an opposition party won a majority of contested LG offices.

It is worth highlighting that election irregularities do not vary meaningfully along partisan lines. Both major political parties, the PDP and the APC, behave similarly in this regard. PDP governors manipulate local elections at the expense of the APC and other opposition in their states the same way that APC governors do, often utilizing identical tactics. That these election irregularities are widespread across both major political parties suggests that the issue is systemic and cannot be solely blamed on any individual leader or party.

Unsurprisingly, opposition parties frequently reject LG election results in various Nigerian states due to alleged electoral irregularities and political interference. For example, in Taraba state, the APC denounced the process as a “charade,” citing incidents where results were declared without actual voting, with claims that SIEC collaborated with the police (Premium Times, 2017). In Niger state, the PDP rejected the elections, citing violence and manipulation, and accused the Niger SIEC of bias favoring the ruling APC. In Oyo State, the APC boycotted elections, criticizing Oyo SIEC’s lack of neutrality even with ongoing litigation over “illegal” dismissals. Occasionally, opposition parties challenge local election results in courts, such as in Osun in 2022, where the All People’s Party alleged that the ballot had only APC candidates (Bamigbola, 2025). Similarly, the LG elections in Ebonyi in 2022 were also nullified by the Federal High Court (Agbodo, 2025). It is also common for opposition parties to boycott LG elections. In 2019, Bayelsa LG elections were boycotted by the All Progressives Congress (APC) (Vanguard, 2019). The APC has also boycotted other LG elections in boycotts in Sokoto, Delta, Edo, Kano, and Katsina states. Similarly, the PDP have boycotted LG elections in Osun, Katsina, and Rivers. These election irregularities have taken their toll on public trust in the electoral system, leading to a significant drop in turnout⁸.

To better understand how Nigerian LG elections end up with the overwhelming victory of the governor’s party, we interviewed some current and previous LG elected officials. We spoke with 10 LG councilors, 1 deputy chairman, and 4 chairmen in January 2024.⁹ All of them had been previously elected. We did not interview any appointed officials. When asked how they were selected to run for office, most interviewee’s response was that they had been members of their (the governor’s) party for a long time and had contributed to the party’s victory in a previous election. They saw their position as a reward for their duties for the party. The majority of them had never met the governor before, but were recommended for the position by a ranking member of the party in the state. Although they had all been formally elected when they were in office, it is striking that they all spoke of their position as if it were handed to them as a reward.

Local research on Nigerian elections often attributes election irregularities to the lack of independence of SIECs (Onah and Ngwu, 2024; Oluwasuji and Okajare, 2021; Wilson, 2013). SIEC officials are perceived as partisan, as highlighted by allegations in Yobe, Ekiti, Kogi, and Kano states. Observers question the

⁸Starting with a peak turnout of 69% in 2003, participation in national elections has consistently declined over the years, reaching only 28.63% in the general elections of 2023 (Chikodiri, 2023). The winner of the 2023 presidential race received fewer than 9 million votes despite the fact that the country has more than 93 million registered voters and a population of 220 million. This has been attributed to the lack of interest of the citizens, poor communication from electoral bodies, and a perceived lack of impact from local governing councils (YIAGA, 2021)

⁹The interviews were approved by the University of Kentucky IRB with protocol #91361.

impartiality of SIEC officials (Premium Times, 2020). A growing consensus among Nigerian political commentators argues that dissolving SIECs and instead tasking the national-level INEC with carrying out local elections would improve the performance of local democratic institutions.

3.3. TESTABLE IMPLICATIONS

Despite Nigeria’s transition to democracy at the turn of the century, the newly democratic institutions fail to meet democratic standards, as our qualitative research above indicates. We argue that Nigeria’s combination of subnational authoritarianism and decentralized electoral institutions are precisely the sort of institutional environment where local elections would fail as accountability mechanisms, and thus local elections would fail to produce the otherwise expected improvements in public service delivery. Whereas existing literature on decentralization suggests that the institution of local elections should lead to an improvement of public goods (Grossman and Slough, 2022), we instead posit that this relationship only works when the administrative work of carrying out local elections is insulated from influence from subnational elites, a criterion that Nigeria does not meet.

Because Nigerian governors inhabit an institutional environment where they face few constraints to their arbitrary rule, and they also have direct influence over the selection of SIEC leadership and staff, authoritarian governors have therefore assumed functional control of the institution of local elections. SIECs, staffed by partisan loyalists, administer the elections in such a way that the incumbent party wins local elections with overwhelming margins that are typically only seen in despotic regimes. As we had previously shown in 1, most local elections result in the incumbent governors’ party winning *all* contested seats. Governors, through their captured SIECs, are able not only able to influence the outcome of elections, they are also able to cancel elections altogether with little consequence. Captured SIECs, at the governors’ command, simply refuse to carry out elections, instead allowing governors to illegally appoint unelected “caretaker committees” to govern LGAs. In short, there is a total failure of democracy at the local level, all occurring within a country that at the national level remains democratic.

Due to the degree of control that governors can exert over local elections, we argue that LG elections in Nigeria cannot serve as accountability mechanisms for local officials, who are thus not incentivized to improve the provision of public goods. Conventional wisdom on decentralized democracy and public goods suggests that elected LGs should deliver better quality public goods than unelected LGs. Variation in the elected status of LG officials allows us to test whether LGAs that are governed by elected officials perform any better than unelected officials with respect to the provision of public services. However, our assessment

of Nigerian state level electoral management bodies suggests that these electoral institutions are captured by state governors, who utilize these institutions to manipulate local elections.

For these reasons, we hypothesize that elected LG officials *will not* perform better than appointed LG officials at delivering public services. Without the independence and impartiality of the electoral institutions, elections cannot serve as an accountability mechanism for local leaders, and, as such, there is no electoral incentive for local leaders to provide better quality public services. In short, we expect to find no relationship between the elected status of LG areas and the quality of public services provided within their jurisdictions.

4. RESEARCH DESIGN

4.1. DATA

To test our theoretical implications, we combine data from several sources. First, we use elected LG status data obtained from Fetzer and Kyburz (2024) and Page and Wando (2022).¹⁰ This data provides records of whether LGs were functioning under the leadership of elected or unelected officials for every given month between May 1999 and December 2013 and 1999 to 2022 respectively.

We use data that correspond to health care service outcomes data period. For the period between 2011 to 2018, we record data that indicates whether that LG was under the control of elected LG officials 6, 12, 18, and 24 months prior to the survey.¹¹ We do this because we assume that it takes time for policies made by LG leaders to affect those living in their jurisdiction. Another consideration for these cut-offs is that term limits for LG officials range between 2 and 3 years.

For service delivery data, we cannot find official government statistics across all states and LGs, as these statistics are not made publicly available. Instead, we turn to the Nigerian General Household Survey (GHS). As part of the Living Standards Measurement Study, these data are collected by Nigeria’s National Bureau of Statistics in partnership with the World Bank and the Gates Foundation. Since this survey is conducted at the national level with foreign partners, we do not expect any relationship with the objectives of any state governors. We assume that the choice of LGs to survey in each round is not correlated with LG elections. We use data from waves 1, 2, 3, and 4 collected in 2011, 2013, 2015, and 2018 respectively. We rely on the post-harvest files for all our analysis. There were 22,788 observations in Wave 1, 27,729 observations for wave 2, 26,176 in wave 3, and 26,557 observations in wave 4.

¹⁰see Kyburz (2018), and Page and Wando (2022) for insights on variation of LG elections across states.

¹¹We also record their elected status as at the time of the survey. However, because respondents are asked questions related to their activities in the four months prior to the survey, we are concerned about identification issues, and so these are not used in all estimations

Although the GHS asks households questions covering a range of topics from health, agriculture, education, credit usage, among others, we are specifically interested in health related questions, since LGs in Nigeria are responsible for providing healthcare.¹² For health related questions, the GHS asks each household member if they had suffered an illness or injury in the 4 months prior to the survey. Those who respond positively to this question are further asked if they have consulted anyone due to their illness or injury. Of the consultation questions asked, we are most concerned with those that allow us to observe individual access to health services in each LG. To this end, we used responses from 4 questions asked about the time traveled to the health consultation, how long respondents waited at the consultation venue before attending, how much the consultation cost them and how much they paid out of pocket for the consultation.

These responses allow us to measure various aspects of access to health services provided in each LG. Time traveled to the consultation helps us measure how far away health facilities are. If respondents have to travel far to access healthcare, then we can infer that there may not be any closer health facilities to them and therefore they may have limited access to healthcare services. If they waited long before being attended to in the health facility, we can infer that there may not have been adequate staff to attend to patients in a timely manner in the health facility. Although the previous measures dealt with the time costs related with access to healthcare in which respondents faced, we also capture the monetary costs incurred while accessing healthcare services. The question on the cost of the consultation is important because it places a monetary value on the health services received. The next question on out-of-pocket payment is equally important as it tells us how much the respondents actually paid themselves. The monetary costs associated with access to healthcare care can limit respondents' access to the service.

To obtain estimates at the LG level on access to healthcare services, we computed averages between respondents within each LG for each of the 4 measures discussed. This gives a LG level estimate for all waves of the GHS, thus creating a pseudo panel data set covering the years 2011, 2013, 2015, and 2018. Descriptive statistics for these measures are shown in section B of the appendix.

4.2. EMPIRICAL STRATEGY

We estimate the empirical effect of having elected LG officials on access to healthcare service delivery across all LGs in Nigeria. We employ a two-way fixed effects model on panel data. The model considers differences between LGs' characteristics and differences within LGs across time.

¹²Schedule 4 section 7 states that LG council's function shall include "the provision and maintenance of health services"

The general function estimated is:

$$Healthcare_{it} = \alpha_i + \lambda_t + \beta X_{it} + \tau Elected_{it} + \epsilon$$

$Healthcare_{it}$ is the outcome variable - the time or monetary cost associated with accessing healthcare services. Where τ is the estimate of interest that captures the effect of elected status on access to healthcare services. $Elected_{it}$ is the elected status of a LG in each time period. X_{it} is a matrix of observed exogenous characteristics of LGs. These covariates may influence the quality of healthcare services provided in each LG. They include the logged values of the FAAC allocations to the LG for the corresponding elected status period, the average distance of households in the LG to a paved road, the major population center in the LG, and the state capital. We also include the logged LG population in 2006. α_i and λ_t are the state/governor, and wave fixed effects. If elections matter, we should see decreased costs associated with access to healthcare across LGAs.

One assumption necessary for our analysis to be identified is that the treatment variable, elected status, must be independent from the outcome. That is, elected status should not be influenced by the quality of health services provided in each LG. As discussed in the previous section, LG elections are under the purview of the governor, the LG officials do not decide when elections happen. As such it is reasonable to assume that the quality of health services provided in LGs does not influence when the governor chooses to hold LG elections.

5. RESULTS

5.1. HEALTHCARE OUTCOMES

Tables 2 and 3 show the results for the estimation of time and monetary costs to accessing healthcare services respectively. The results show that elected status 6 months before the survey may reduce the travel times to the consultation. However, this result disappears once we include fixed effects. There is no consistent evidence that elected status 12, 18, or 24 months prior to the survey decreases the time traveled to the consultation. Similarly, it appears that the elected status of the LG 6 months before the survey decreases the average wait times to be seen at the consultation. This is the case even when covariates or state and wave fixed effects have been accounted for though not for when we include governor fixed effects. In short, for both time and traveled to the consultation and the wait times before being seen at the consultation, we find no consistently significant results that LG elected status improves them.

Table 2: Effect of Elected Status on Time Costs of Healthcare Access

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Panel A: Travel Time to Consultation</i>						
Elected (6 months)	−0.1277*** (0.0373)	−0.0354 (0.0348)	−0.0027 (0.0437)	−0.1229*** (0.0335)	−0.0443 (0.0349)	−0.0081 (0.0441)
Elected (12 months)	0.0061 (0.0345)	0.0232 (0.0396)	0.0083 (0.0524)	−0.0265 (0.0311)	0.0199 (0.0394)	0.0029 (0.0526)
Elected (18 months)	0.0379 (0.0297)	0.0234 (0.0406)	−0.0114 (0.0459)	−0.0006 (0.0372)	0.0259 (0.0413)	−0.0109 (0.0475)
Elected (24 months)	0.0222 (0.0341)	0.0563* (0.0319)	0.0341 (0.0400)	0.0263 (0.0341)	0.0662** (0.0309)	0.0441 (0.0388)
<i>Panel B: Wait Time at Consultation</i>						
Elected (6 months)	−0.2294*** (0.0545)	−0.1405** (0.0540)	−0.0649 (0.0759)	−0.2105*** (0.0510)	−0.1400** (0.0553)	−0.0622 (0.0773)
Elected (12 months)	−0.0358 (0.0578)	−0.0117 (0.0615)	0.0109 (0.0837)	−0.0677 (0.0543)	−0.0089 (0.0617)	0.0061 (0.0849)
Elected (18 months)	0.0445 (0.0521)	0.0902 (0.0623)	0.1123 (0.0790)	0.0390 (0.0581)	0.0854 (0.0641)	0.1036 (0.0823)
Elected (24 months)	0.0448 (0.0543)	0.0974 (0.0639)	0.0866 (0.0775)	0.0381 (0.0562)	0.0913 (0.0647)	0.0870 (0.0780)
Covariates	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	No
Governor FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Wave FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i> (Panel A)	1,511	1,511	1,511	1,473	1,473	1,473
<i>N</i> (Panel B)	1,492	1,492	1,492	1,454	1,454	1,454
Clusters	36	36	36	36	36	36

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. The unit of analysis is the LGA. Data are from waves 1–4 of the GHS (2011, 2013, 2015, 2018). All outcomes are log-transformed. Covariates include logged FAAC allocations (matched to lag period), average distance to major roads, distance to large populated areas, distance to state capital, and logged population. Sample sizes differ across panels due to missing data.

Next, we turn to the results from the estimation of elected status on the monetary costs of access to healthcare services across LGs presented in Table 3. In all specifications, we find no indication that the elected status 6 months or 12 months prior to the survey decreases the monetary costs of access to healthcare in LGs. In fact, there is some evidence that elections both 6 months, 12 and 18 months prior to the survey may increase the cost of consultations although this effect disappears when wave, state or governor fixed effects are included. These results, do not lead us to conclude that elections are beneficial for the delivery of healthcare services.

Table 3: Effect of Elected Status on Monetary Costs of Healthcare Access

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Panel A: Consultation Cost</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.0801 (0.1701)	0.2445* (0.1392)	0.2197 (0.1668)	0.0858 (0.1536)	0.2395 (0.1438)	0.2015 (0.1677)
Elected (12 months)	0.2839** (0.1234)	0.2131 (0.1482)	0.1783 (0.2117)	0.2193 (0.1304)	0.2055 (0.1512)	0.1650 (0.2141)
Elected (18 months)	0.2234* (0.1275)	0.1018 (0.1276)	0.0380 (0.1341)	0.2162 (0.1605)	0.1267 (0.1352)	0.0604 (0.1376)
Elected (24 months)	0.0796 (0.1636)	0.0977 (0.1123)	-0.0212 (0.1483)	0.0531 (0.1630)	0.1078 (0.1168)	-0.0044 (0.1504)
<i>Panel B: Out-of-Pocket Payment</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.2027 (0.1779)	0.1206 (0.2006)	0.1734 (0.4473)	0.2007 (0.1730)	0.0836 (0.2048)	0.1280 (0.4473)
Elected (12 months)	-0.0559 (0.1766)	0.1210 (0.2235)	0.3368 (0.3601)	-0.0512 (0.1807)	0.0975 (0.2235)	0.3145 (0.3587)
Elected (18 months)	0.0689 (0.1537)	0.2822 (0.2368)	0.2084 (0.4009)	0.1792 (0.1711)	0.2861 (0.2379)	0.2277 (0.4002)
Elected (24 months)	0.0484 (0.2251)	0.4251* (0.2102)	0.3354 (0.3891)	0.1141 (0.2086)	0.4845** (0.1999)	0.3586 (0.3739)
Covariates	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	No
Governor FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Wave FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i> (Panel A)	1,401	1,401	1,401	1,367	1,367	1,367
<i>N</i> (Panel B)	960	960	960	944	944	944
Clusters	36	36	36	36	36	36

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. See Table 2 notes for variable definitions. All outcomes are log-transformed. Sample sizes differ across panels due to missing data.

5.2. ADDITIONAL RESULTS USING A 2 X 2 DIFFERENCE IN DIFFERENCE DESIGN

We are cautious of our results at this stage for two reasons; first, we use a pseudo-panel with non-consecutive years to draw inference. Secondly, our observations are treated at different time periods, with most LGs in a state like Zamfara never experiencing elections throughout the period we analyze, and most of those in Lagos having elections in every period. Though our two-way fixed effects design is a variant of the Difference in Difference (DiD) design, there is no clear treated and control group that remains stable throughout the time periods (see Section A of the Online Appendix for this breakdown). The LGs in Lagos are in the always treated group, and those of Zamfara in the never treated group. All other LGs go in and out of elected status throughout our 4 time periods. This may be a concern as recent innovations in how we understand

differences in difference designs have shown that what the two-way fixed effects model does not estimate what we may assume it does (Goodman-Bacon, 2021; Baker et al., 2025). Other works have shown ways to avoid the multiple time periods in the data (de Chaisemartin and d’Haultfoeuille, 2024; Callaway and Sant’Anna, 2021).

To address this potential problem, we subset our data to waves 3 and 4 of the GHS. All states included in our subset sample are those that did not have elections in wave 3. Some of them had elected LG officials in wave 4. This creates a 2 x 2 scenario where we have a pre-period without elected officials and a post-period where some LGs had elected officials while the remaining remained without elected officials. Following de Chaisemartin and d’Haultfoeuille (2024), we assume that the treatment in the previous period does not influence the results in the next period. So, treatment status in waves 1 and 2 should not be correlated with the outcomes in waves 3 or 4. We then reestimate our equation using this sample. The results are displayed in Table 4.

Table 4: Clean 2x2 DiD Results: Waves 3–4 Subset

	Travel Time	Wait Time	Consult. Cost	Out-of-Pocket
<i>6-month lag</i>				
Elected (6 months)	−0.155 (0.104)	−0.068 (0.197)	0.201 (0.482)	1.260 (0.798)
<i>12-month lag</i>				
Elected (12 months)	−0.079 (0.078)	0.078 (0.164)	−0.418 (0.506)	−0.335 (1.207)
<i>N</i>	282	281	283	143
States	15	15	15	15

Notes: Estimates with state and wave fixed effects from the waves 3–4 subsample restricted to states without elected LGA officials in wave 3. Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. All outcomes are log-transformed. Out-of-pocket estimates use OLS because state fixed effects absorb the treatment variable in the small subsample ($N = 143$). *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

We find no evidence that elected status of LGs influences the time traveled to the consultation, wait times at the consultation, or the cost of the consultation. Although we had previously found evidence that elected status decreases waiting times and increases the cost of consultations, we now find that these results are not robust to other research design specifications. Additionally, we conduct other robustness checks which are discussed in section C of the online appendix. First we limit our sample to LGs that are surveyed in all waves of the GHS, and we reestimate our equations using the individual results. The results show no substantive differences to those presented here.

5.3. MODERN DiD ESTIMATORS

To further address the issues mentioned in the previous section, we complement our TWFE analysis using modern DiD estimators. Table 5 compares our baseline TWFE estimates (specification 2: state + wave FE, 12-month lag) with the de Chaisemartin and d’Haultfoeuille (2024) estimator. The DCDH estimator produces estimates that are consistent with the TWFE results: all point estimates are statistically insignificant, confirming that the null finding is not an artifact of TWFE bias from heterogeneous treatment effects or forbidden comparisons. The DCDH estimator is particularly appropriate because it accommodates our reversible treatment structure; the Callaway & Sant’Anna and Goodman-Bacon methods cannot be applied (see Section D of the Online Appendix for details). The consistency between our TWFE and DCDH estimates provides reassurance that conventional TWFE bias is not driving our null results.

Table 5: Comparison of TWFE and Modern DiD Estimates

Outcome	TWFE		DCDH	
	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Travel time	0.153	(0.113)	−0.004	(0.169)
Wait time	0.142	(0.125)	0.184	(0.188)
Consultation cost	0.150	(0.252)	0.604	(0.588)
Out-of-pocket	0.103	(0.452)	0.446	(0.961)

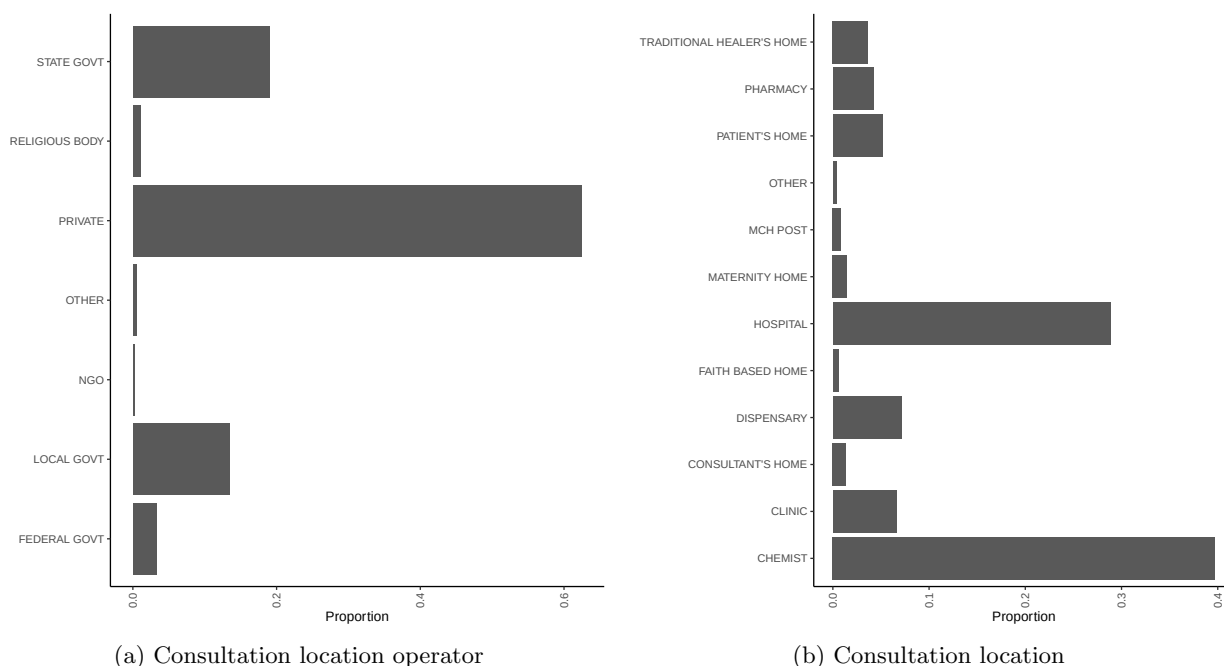
Notes: TWFE estimates are from specification (2) with state and wave fixed effects (12-month lag). DCDH estimates are from the de Chaisemartin and d’Haultfoeuille (2024) dynamic estimator with state-level clustering. All outcomes are log-transformed. None of the estimates are statistically significant at conventional levels.

5.4. ARE GOVERNMENT ESTABLISHMENTS PROVIDING HEALTH SERVICES TO RESPONDENTS?

To further investigate the lack of a significant relationship between local elected status and various health service outcomes, we turn back to the raw survey data. The panel 2a shows the distribution of ownership of the healthcare facilities visited by the respondents. The majority of respondents visited private establishments. In addition to visiting private healthcare providers, we also observe that respondents are less likely to visit a hospital or a clinic compared to places like chemists, dispensaries, and traditional healers. The panel 2b shows the distribution of places that survey respondents listed to go for consultations when they experience a disease or injury. This is in line with Gupta et al. (2003), who shows that healthcare services at the local level are provided mainly by private firms. A survey of health care services in Nigeria revealed a lack of transparency in funding, with unpaid staff salaries and unaccounted for funding in government health centers (Gupta et al., 2003; Khemani, 2006).

We observe that less than 20 percent of the respondents reported visiting health facilities operated by the LG, and it is somewhat clearer why the elected status of the LG may not have an effect on access to healthcare. The reason why local elections do not have an effect on health care service delivery may be that the public do not visit LG healthcare facilities. We investigate this claim, using individual-level data from the GHS, creating two dependent variables, one indicating whether respondents visit any government healthcare facility and another indicating whether they visit a LG healthcare facility. We regress these outcomes on the elected status of the LG in which the respondent resides 6 months before the survey and 12 months before the survey. The results are presented in Table 6.

Figure 2: Consultation facilities and their operators



Note: Panel 2a shows the organizations that own and operate the consultation locations respondents attended. Panel 2b shows the distribution of places respondents in the GHS went for their health consultations when they were ill or had an injury in the 4 months prior to the survey.

Table 6: Effect of Elected Status on Healthcare Facility Utilization

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Panel A: Consulted Medical Professional</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.0046 (0.0054)	-0.0056 (0.0040)	-0.0014 (0.0051)	0.0024 (0.0049)	-0.0049 (0.0041)	-0.0007 (0.0054)
Elected (12 months)	0.0019 (0.0053)	-0.0026 (0.0055)	0.0043 (0.0062)	0.0040 (0.0051)	-0.0029 (0.0054)	0.0046 (0.0065)
Elected (18 months)	-0.0043 (0.0053)	-0.0029 (0.0049)	-0.0053 (0.0055)	-0.0044 (0.0053)	-0.0036 (0.0049)	-0.0056 (0.0058)
Elected (24 months)	-0.0042 (0.0065)	-0.0022 (0.0059)	0.0016 (0.0068)	-0.0050 (0.0063)	-0.0026 (0.0060)	0.0024 (0.0069)
<i>Panel B: Consulted at Medical Facility</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.0058 (0.0049)	-0.0027 (0.0039)	0.0023 (0.0050)	0.0038 (0.0047)	-0.0025 (0.0039)	0.0026 (0.0054)
Elected (12 months)	0.0031 (0.0049)	-0.0012 (0.0046)	0.0061 (0.0055)	0.0049 (0.0049)	-0.0016 (0.0047)	0.0063 (0.0060)
Elected (18 months)	-0.0008 (0.0047)	0.0021 (0.0042)	0.0028 (0.0053)	-0.0010 (0.0047)	0.0016 (0.0042)	0.0029 (0.0058)
Elected (24 months)	-0.0020 (0.0063)	-0.0002 (0.0051)	0.0040 (0.0056)	-0.0023 (0.0061)	-0.0001 (0.0052)	0.0051 (0.0059)
<i>Panel C: Visited Government Establishment</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.0001 (0.0051)	-0.0018 (0.0034)	0.0030 (0.0038)	-0.0006 (0.0051)	-0.0013 (0.0033)	0.0038 (0.0039)
Elected (12 months)	0.0044 (0.0053)	0.0029 (0.0041)	0.0095* (0.0054)	0.0058 (0.0057)	0.0025 (0.0042)	0.0100* (0.0057)
Elected (18 months)	0.0020 (0.0045)	0.0048 (0.0040)	0.0074 (0.0049)	0.0017 (0.0047)	0.0039 (0.0039)	0.0067 (0.0048)
Elected (24 months)	0.0056 (0.0051)	0.0045 (0.0046)	0.0088 (0.0057)	0.0059 (0.0049)	0.0050 (0.0047)	0.0093 (0.0057)
<i>Panel D: Visited LG Establishment</i>						
Elected (6 months)	-0.0406 (0.0266)	-0.0231 (0.0145)	-0.0269 (0.0243)	-0.0418 (0.0265)	-0.0290* (0.0166)	-0.0309 (0.0244)
Elected (12 months)	0.0131 (0.0287)	-0.0072 (0.0171)	0.0108 (0.0223)	0.0118 (0.0303)	-0.0119 (0.0188)	0.0074 (0.0236)
Elected (18 months)	0.0045 (0.0256)	-0.0195 (0.0159)	0.0025 (0.0194)	-0.0016 (0.0284)	-0.0235 (0.0178)	-0.0042 (0.0206)
Elected (24 months)	0.0284 (0.0259)	-0.0064 (0.0181)	0.0067 (0.0195)	0.0198 (0.0247)	-0.0034 (0.0177)	0.0105 (0.0184)
Covariates	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
LGA FE	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	No
Governor FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Wave FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i> (Panel A)	103,447	103,447	103,447	99,975	99,975	99,975
<i>N</i> (Panel B)	103,447	103,447	103,447	99,975	99,975	99,975
<i>N</i> (Panel C)	103,447	103,447	103,447	99,975	99,975	99,975
<i>N</i> (Panel D)	13,938	13,938	13,938	13,455	13,455	13,455
Clusters	36	36	36	36	36	36

Notes: Individual-level linear probability models. Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. All outcomes are binary (0/1). Data from GHS waves 1–4 (2011, 2013, 2015, 2018). Covariates include logged FAAC allocations (matched to lag period), average distance to major roads, distance to large populated areas, distance to state capital, and logged population. Sample sizes differ across panels due to missing data.

The results in Table 6 do not show that elected status of the LG increases the probability that respondents would choose to visit either government healthcare facilities or specifically LG facilities. Each panel shows two estimates, the first of which is a baseline model with the dependent variable of visiting a government establishment regressed on the elected status of the LG either 6 months or 12 months prior to the survey. Second, we add LG and wave fixed effects to the baseline model. Standard errors across all estimated models are clustered by household and LG to account for any spillovers in illnesses by location and proximity to other respondents. We find no effect of LG elected status on the probability respondents visit any government facility or LG specific facilities either.

5.5. ARE THE RESULTS SERVICE SPECIFIC? ADDITIONAL EVIDENCE FROM EDUCATION PROVISION

One might be concerned that we consistently find no association between local elected status and health care service outcomes and conclude that we get these results because of the outcome we have chosen to study. To address this issue, we look at education provision by LGs. LGs in Nigeria are also tasked with the provision of education to the public. The GHS also asks respondents questions related to their current school attendance in the wave they were surveyed. Of these questions, we are interested in the school enrollment status, the time it takes to get to school, and how much school fees and tuition cost the respondent. Like we have done for health outcomes, we average these across LGs to obtain LG level estimates for the proportion of children in school, the average amount paid in school fees, and the average time it takes to get to school.

Table 7 shows the results from our estimations of the effect of elected status on educational outcomes. Like with health outcomes, we find no consistent association between elected LG status and educational outcomes across various specifications including state, governor, and wave fixed effects or when covariates are included in estimations.

Table 7: Effect of Elected Status on Education Outcomes

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Panel A: Proportion of Children in School</i>						
Elected (6 months)	−0.0538 (0.0435)	0.0281 (0.0258)	0.0349 (0.0321)	−0.0339 (0.0407)	0.0237 (0.0244)	0.0310 (0.0305)
Elected (12 months)	0.0669 (0.0455)	0.0529** (0.0243)	0.0752** (0.0290)	0.0511 (0.0409)	0.0478* (0.0239)	0.0727** (0.0285)
Elected (18 months)	0.0698 (0.0425)	0.0247 (0.0257)	0.0384 (0.0292)	0.0520 (0.0421)	0.0294 (0.0247)	0.0458 (0.0282)
Elected (24 months)	0.0982** (0.0439)	0.0120 (0.0270)	0.0086 (0.0304)	0.0934** (0.0408)	0.0160 (0.0263)	0.0132 (0.0297)
<i>Panel B: School Fees (Naira)</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.1391 (0.2843)	−0.0882 (0.1486)	−0.0279 (0.1711)	−0.0494 (0.2308)	−0.0469 (0.1461)	−0.0162 (0.1676)
Elected (12 months)	−0.2616 (0.2751)	−0.0077 (0.1732)	0.0511 (0.1825)	−0.2297 (0.2309)	0.0185 (0.1717)	0.0603 (0.1851)
Elected (18 months)	−0.3845 (0.2610)	−0.1257 (0.1346)	−0.1288 (0.1401)	−0.2925 (0.2303)	−0.1255 (0.1296)	−0.1204 (0.1352)
Elected (24 months)	−0.1499 (0.2561)	−0.0727 (0.1348)	−0.0828 (0.1438)	−0.2064 (0.2294)	−0.1241 (0.1363)	−0.1071 (0.1505)
<i>Panel C: Travel Time to School</i>						
Elected (6 months)	−0.0167 (0.0428)	0.0013 (0.0294)	0.0268 (0.0223)	−0.0042 (0.0406)	0.0052 (0.0287)	0.0247 (0.0222)
Elected (12 months)	−0.0003 (0.0406)	0.0286 (0.0285)	0.0423** (0.0197)	0.0102 (0.0372)	0.0286 (0.0277)	0.0371* (0.0184)
Elected (18 months)	−0.0131 (0.0341)	−0.0199 (0.0263)	−0.0148 (0.0280)	−0.0139 (0.0344)	−0.0201 (0.0254)	−0.0133 (0.0263)
Elected (24 months)	−0.0654* (0.0375)	−0.0234 (0.0304)	−0.0132 (0.0279)	−0.0707* (0.0372)	−0.0296 (0.0318)	−0.0190 (0.0280)
Covariates	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	No
Governor FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Wave FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i> (Panel A)	1,005	1,005	1,005	978	978	978
<i>N</i> (Panel B)	731	731	731	711	711	711
<i>N</i> (Panel C)	1,005	1,005	1,005	978	978	978
Clusters	36	36	36	36	36	36

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. All outcomes are log-transformed. See Table 2 notes for covariate definitions. Sample sizes differ across panels due to missing data.

5.6. PUBLIC OPINION ON LOCAL GOVERNMENTS

We now consider why respondents may not visit government health facilities when they experience an illness or injury. One possibility is that respondents do not trust the LG with their health when they experience an illness or injury. To evaluate this possibility, we turn to survey data from the Afrobarometer. Afrobarometer respondents are asked some questions about their perception of LG officials. Of particular interest to this paper are questions on their trust in the LG officials, perceptions of corruption among LG officials, and perceived performance of LG officials. We use data for these questions from round 5 and 6 of the survey which were collected in 2012 and 2015. These rounds of the Afrobarometer were collected during a time range similar to the data from the GHS, making them an ideal pairing. We record the corresponding elected status for the months in which the surveys were carried out. Like with previous estimations, we use elected status for 6 and 12 months prior to the surveys. The results are shown in Table 8.

There is some evidence that respondents approve of elected LG officials performance 12 months after the election. This result is robust to the inclusion of LG and governor fixed effects. This is despite our results showing that there is no difference in the performance of elected or unelected LG officials on healthcare or education. Respondents may simply prefer elected officials over unelected ones.

Table 8: Public Perceptions of Local Government Officials by Elected Status

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Panel A: Contacted LG Officials</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.0138 (0.0394)	0.0887 (0.0722)	0.0867 (0.0718)	0.0242 (0.0368)	0.0933 (0.0714)	0.0922 (0.0713)
Elected (12 months)	-0.0087 (0.0271)	0.0669 (0.0713)	0.0672 (0.0717)	-0.0108 (0.0244)	0.0727 (0.0693)	0.0730 (0.0696)
Elected (18 months)	-0.0007 (0.0265)	0.0773 (0.0604)	0.0765 (0.0613)	-0.0020 (0.0237)	0.0766 (0.0621)	0.0757 (0.0630)
Elected (24 months)	-0.0395 (0.0310)	0.0780 (0.0731)	0.0851 (0.0739)	-0.0415 (0.0304)	0.0769 (0.0739)	0.0824 (0.0750)
<i>Panel B: Trust in LG Officials</i>						
Elected (6 months)	-0.0378 (0.0507)	0.0421 (0.0518)	0.0502 (0.0506)	-0.0199 (0.0439)	0.0491 (0.0514)	0.0584 (0.0482)
Elected (12 months)	-0.0413 (0.0486)	0.0753 (0.0847)	0.0743 (0.0844)	-0.0418 (0.0429)	0.0705 (0.0848)	0.0711 (0.0834)
Elected (18 months)	-0.0601 (0.0447)	0.0567 (0.0714)	0.0599 (0.0701)	-0.0581 (0.0393)	0.0513 (0.0716)	0.0555 (0.0695)
Elected (24 months)	-0.0553 (0.0369)	0.0793 (0.0771)	0.0618 (0.0749)	-0.0598* (0.0330)	0.0743 (0.0763)	0.0543 (0.0732)
<i>Panel C: LG Officials Corrupt</i>						
Elected (6 months)	-0.0112 (0.0071)	-0.0105 (0.0216)	-0.0096 (0.0216)	-0.0118* (0.0070)	-0.0101 (0.0218)	-0.0086 (0.0216)
Elected (12 months)	-0.0083 (0.0073)	-0.0093 (0.0123)	-0.0094 (0.0126)	-0.0086 (0.0075)	-0.0102 (0.0120)	-0.0099 (0.0123)
Elected (18 months)	-0.0110 (0.0065)	-0.0157 (0.0152)	-0.0153 (0.0152)	-0.0115* (0.0067)	-0.0165 (0.0150)	-0.0160 (0.0151)
Elected (24 months)	0.0014 (0.0072)	-0.0057 (0.0207)	-0.0081 (0.0208)	0.0013 (0.0073)	-0.0055 (0.0210)	-0.0087 (0.0209)
<i>Panel D: LG Officials Listen to Citizens</i>						
Elected (6 months)	0.0221 (0.0619)	-0.1331 (0.1365)	-0.1314 (0.1385)	0.0366 (0.0582)	-0.1334 (0.1303)	-0.1297 (0.1329)
Elected (12 months)	0.0160 (0.0557)	-0.0660 (0.0711)	-0.0663 (0.0713)	0.0089 (0.0521)	-0.0613 (0.0675)	-0.0602 (0.0672)
Elected (18 months)	0.0717 (0.0614)	0.0181 (0.0950)	0.0190 (0.0952)	0.0666 (0.0580)	0.0167 (0.0911)	0.0186 (0.0912)
Elected (24 months)	-0.1035* (0.0550)	0.1039 (0.1065)	0.1007 (0.1092)	-0.1066** (0.0525)	0.0987 (0.1053)	0.0920 (0.1081)
<i>Panel E: Approve of LG Performance</i>						
Elected (6 months)	-0.0714 (0.0552)	0.1941 (0.1427)	0.1995 (0.1408)	-0.0509 (0.0503)	0.2070 (0.1457)	0.2124 (0.1442)
Elected (12 months)	-0.0016 (0.0547)	0.1257** (0.0614)	0.1251* (0.0632)	-0.0034 (0.0484)	0.1194** (0.0569)	0.1190** (0.0584)
Elected (18 months)	-0.0823* (0.0450)	-0.0005 (0.1033)	0.0015 (0.1029)	-0.0817** (0.0402)	-0.0067 (0.1031)	-0.0051 (0.1025)
Elected (24 months)	0.0150 (0.0472)	0.0099 (0.0919)	-0.0004 (0.0943)	0.0084 (0.0430)	0.0006 (0.0913)	-0.0093 (0.0948)
Covariates	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
LGA FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Governor FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Round FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
N (Panel A)	4,727	4,727	4,727	4,727	4,727	4,727
N (Panel B)	4,674	4,674	4,674	4,674	4,674	4,674
N (Panel C)	4,649	4,649	4,649	4,649	4,649	4,649
N (Panel D)	4,628	4,628	4,628	4,628	4,628	4,628
N (Panel E)	4,561	4,561	4,561	4,561	4,561	4,561
Clusters	36	36	36	36	36	36

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. All outcomes are binary (0/1). Data from Afrobarometer rounds 5 and 6 (2012, 2014/2015). Individual-level covariates include age, gender, language, religion, urban/rural dwelling, education, and employment status. Sample sizes differ across panels due to missing data.

6. DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Taken together, our null results show that there is no identifiable relationship between elected LG status and healthcare outcomes in Nigeria. Our evidence suggests that LG officials who entered office through elections perform no better with respect to health care service outcomes than officials who were directly appointed in lieu of elections. This conclusion is robust to different model specifications and research designs. Although survey respondents report approval of the performance of elected LG officials in their jobs, this does not appear to encourage usage of LG-run health facilities. Power analysis available in section C4 of the online appendix imply that our null results are not due to insufficient power in our specifications and analysis.

This research provides an example of a failure of democratization and decentralization to promote better outcomes for public goods. We show that the introduction of electoral institutions at the subnational level do not function as an effective accountability mechanism, due to subnational authoritarianism and the capture of electoral institutions by state governors. Our results speak to a broader literature on subnational authoritarianism, by illustrating an example of a country that has transitioned to democracy at the national level and yet still contains authoritarian governance at the subnational level. Our work aligns with other existing literature, showing that decentralization and local democracy are not sufficient conditions for improving the provision of public goods, as such institutions can still be vulnerable to elite capture.

There are two institutional features of Nigeria’s democracy that contribute most to this failure of local electoral institutions to enable better public goods. First, the State Independent Electoral Commissions (SIECs), which are responsible for carrying out local elections within their respective Nigerian states, do not seem to actually operate independently. These commissions have frequently been subject to accusations of partisanship and political manipulation, and the frequency of canceled elections or overwhelming incumbent party victories serving as compelling evidence. In order for local elections to serve as an effective accountability mechanism for political parties, the commissions responsible for carrying out elections must be granted true independence and operate without pressure from state governors. We agree with the assessment provided by Nigerian scholars, calling for an independent and centralized national EMB to assume responsibility for overseeing subnational elections (Onah and Ngwu, 2024; Oluwasuji and Okajare, 2021; Wilson, 2013).

Second, state governments assuming de facto control over LG budgets creates an incentive for interfering in local elections. As noted by Khemani (2006), there is a lack of transparency of spending on health care services, with much of the funding being unaccounted for, leading to suspicions of embezzlement. We agree with Khemani’s assessment that an increase in transparency and information availability could help ensure

that funding that is allocated for LG areas is indeed spent on improving public goods. Furthermore, a critical step forward is the implementation of a 2024 Supreme Court ruling on this issue, asserting that only elected LGs should receive federal funding, and that this funding should go directly to the accounts of the 774 local councils, rather than entrusting state governments to allocate that funding. However, as of 2025, LGs do not yet have accounts, and federal allocations are still being directed to state governments.

Future research on this topic, especially in Nigeria, should investigate the sources of variation on electoral status across LGAs Nigerian states. Why do some Nigerian governors choose to cancel elections and instead illegally appoint councils? Why do other governors choose to hold local elections. Recent work by Fetzer and Kyburz (2024) on distributive conflict may suggest a possible answer. Perhaps Nigerian governors' decision to hold or withhold local elections is motivated, at least in part, by a calculus about distributive outcomes. Indeed, our own supplemental qualitative research here suggests that Nigerian governors have sought to control these funding flows. However, the overwhelming incumbent party victories in these elections complicates would complicate this explanation. For this reason, additional research on this topic is necessary.

Additional further research could investigate Nigerian local elections themselves, especially the low turnout. An investigation into the characteristics and motivations of voters could illuminate why incumbent parties often win overwhelmingly in local elections. Research on vote-buying and clientelism (Khemani, 2015) draws a connection with underinvestment in public goods, which could apply to the Nigerian context. Additionally, while our qualitative research does reveal that Nigerian governors often cancel or delay local elections with little apparent political cost, and allowing elections to take place rarely leads to a defeat of the incumbent party, further research could investigate the strategic motivations of governors when determining whether to hold elections or to instead install appointees. Future research should more closely examine the critical role that EMBs play in ensuring the conduct of free and fair elections, and preserving the legitimacy of democracy itself.

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